

Growing Together Through Organic Entrepreneurship: The Journey of Pooja

"We wanted to build a business around what our village already had. Instead of searching for opportunities elsewhere, we decided to create value from our own local resources."



Background

For Pooja starting her business was not just about doing something by herself. It was about helping a lot of women at the same time. Pooja lives in a village called Naganpat in Dharamshala, which's in the Kangra district of Himachal Pradesh. Pooja is part of a group that is led by women and this group, which is called a Self Help Group is trying to get people to buy products that are grown locally by women like Pooja.

The group makes a variety of extra products, including organic red rice, black wheat, black rice, honey that is made locally, Kasturi Basmati rice and garlic pickles. Every product shows the farming abundance of the area

while encouraging food choices by using farming methods that do not have chemicals.

The business started one year ago with a strong idea of supporting organic products that are available nearby and helping women in the community find work and earn a living.

"हमने सोचा कि हमारे गाँव में जो संसाधन पहले से उपलब्ध हैं, उन्हीं को बेहतर तरीके से लोगों तक पहुँचाया जाए।"

The Entrepreneurial Journey

Before selecting their products, the group did not make decisions randomly. Instead, they carefully observed changing consumer preferences and conducted informal market research.

Pooja explains that increasing awareness about healthy food and organic farming encouraged the group to focus on products that already had growing demand in the market.

"हमने पहले मार्केट रिसर्च किया। हमने देखा कि लोग क्या खरीद रहे हैं और आजकल लोग ऑर्गेनिक और लोकल उत्पादों की तरफ ज़्यादा रुचि दिखा रहे हैं।"

Based on this understanding, the group selected products that could be sourced locally. Since garlic is widely cultivated in their area, they decided to prepare garlic pickles rather than depending on raw materials from distant markets. Similarly, locally grown red rice, black wheat, black rice, honey, and Kasturi Basmati became the foundation of their enterprise.

This approach helped the group reduce procurement costs while promoting products that reflected the identity of their region.



Business Growth

The business is one year old but it has been a tough journey so far. The business has had to deal with a lot of challenges. One of the problems was finding the right machines to process black wheat and speciality rice.

The group found out that the usual machines that remove the grains from the plants were actually damaging the wheat and speciality rice. So they had to find machines that could handle these grains. The Cluster Level Federation and the people, in charge of the blocks helped the group find the machines they needed.

Another problem the business faced was finding people to work. When the business was just starting out the people who owned the business had to do a lot of the work themselves. The members of the Self Help Group helped out by cleaning and sorting the products and getting them ready to sell.

They did all this work before the business was making any money.

Pooja recalls,

"शुरुआत में हम महिलाओं को भुगतान नहीं कर पा रहे थे, लेकिन हमने एक-दूसरे से वादा किया कि जैसे-जैसे व्यवसाय आगे बढ़ेगा, लाभ हम सब मिलकर बाँटेंगे।"

This shared commitment became one of the strongest foundations of the enterprise.

Today, the group is introducing its products through local markets, government institutions, and nearby communities. While they are currently focusing on local sales, they aspire to expand to larger markets in the future.

Learning Through the IIT Delhi Training

Pooja thinks that making products is just one part of making a business successful. She went to the Entrepreneurship Development training conducted by IIT Delhi. It really helped her. She learned how to plan a business by using technologies and manage money, which can make a community-based business stronger. The Entrepreneurship Development Programme by IIT Delhi taught Pooja that business planning and digital technologies and financial management are very important for a community-based enterprise, like hers. Reflecting on the training, she shares,

"इस प्रशिक्षण ने मुझे यह समझाया कि केवल उत्पाद तैयार करना ही पर्याप्त नहीं है। यदि हमें अपने व्यवसाय को आगे बढ़ाना है, तो हमें ग्राहकों तक पहुँचने, डिजिटल माध्यमों का उपयोग करने और अपने व्यवसाय का सही प्रबंधन करना भी सीखना होगा।"



The sessions on digital literacy encouraged her to explore new ways of promoting the group's products. She realised that digital platforms can help them introduce their organic products to customers beyond their local area and gradually expand into larger markets.

She also appreciated the sessions on financial literacy, which highlighted the importance of maintaining proper business records.

"अब मुझे समझ आया है कि व्यवसाय में केवल बिक्री ही महत्वपूर्ण नहीं होती, बल्कि आय, खर्च, लागत और लाभ का सही रिकॉर्ड रखना भी उतना ही ज़रूरी है। इससे आगे की योजना बनाना आसान होगा।"

The training also strengthened her confidence to represent the group, interact with customers, and explore future business opportunities with greater clarity.

Looking Ahead

The company is still new. It has already made back the money it started with. Now it is getting to the point where it will start making a profit.

For Pooja this is the start.

She wants to sell the groups products to more people make the products look better and get them to customers outside of Himachal Pradesh. At the time Pooja wants more women in her community to start their own companies like this one so they can have good jobs and make a living that is good for the environment and will last. Pooja thinks that organic products, from the group can really make a difference.

"मुझे सबसे ज़्यादा खुशी इस बात की है कि मैं कुछ नया कर रही हूँ। मैं चाहती हूँ कि हमारा व्यवसाय आगे बढ़े और इससे हमारे समूह की सभी महिलाओं को लाभ मिले।"